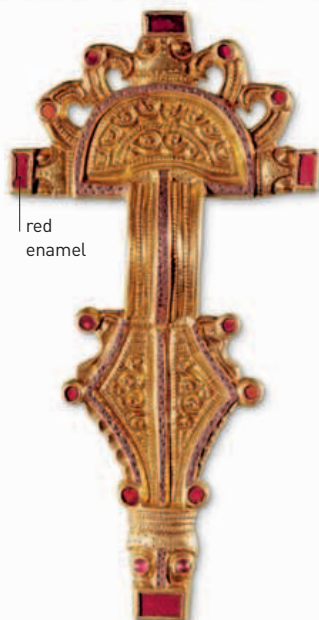




These 6th-century ivory panels show Emperor Anastasius. He amassed a vast financial surplus, which his successors spent on expanding the Eastern Roman Empire.

IN THE EASTERN ROMAN EMPIRE (generally called the **Byzantine Empire** from about this date), **Anastasius** (r. 491–518) faced difficulties in the Balkans, as new groups, including the **Bulgars**, pressed southward across the Danube between 493 and 502. More serious were **problems on the eastern frontier**, where the **Persians** insisted on Byzantine financial subsidies to pay for the defense of strategic passes in the Caucasus against barbarian incursions. In 502, the **Persian ruler Kavadh** began a war over the issue; the slow Byzantine reaction allowed him to capture Amida as well as several towns in Armenia. Byzantine forces retook Amida in 505, and Kavadh—preoccupied with a Hephthalite invasion in the east—agreed a truce, which lasted until 527.

Anastasius was almost 60 when he **became emperor** in 491, and his place on the throne was only secured by his marriage in 492 to Ariadne, widow of his predecessor **Zeno**. Almost immediately Zeno's brother **Longinus** revolted, and it took six years for Anastasius to subdue Longinus's home area of **Isauria** (in western Asia Minor). Anastasius gained popularity by abolishing the **chrysargyron tax** for traders and craftsmen. Prosperity continued and over his reign his treasury amassed a surplus of 320,000 pounds of gold. He also implemented monetary reforms in 498 and 512 aimed at stabilizing the currency, which had suffered successive debasements in the 5th century. In religious



Frankish fibula brooch

Fibula brooches were practical as well as decorative, being used to fasten clothes. This brooch is decorated with the heads of birds.

terms Anastasius's reign was less tranquil, as he was a follower of **Monophysite Christianity**, which held that Christ had only a single divine nature and did not combine human and divine in his person. At first, Anastasius supported Zeno's **Henotikon**—an "act of union" issued in 482 that tried to broker a compromise between supporters of the orthodox creed (established at the Council of Chalcedon in 452) and the Monophysites. However, later his attitude became more pro-Monophysite, which led to serious rioting in 512, and the revolt of an

army officer, **Vitalian**, in Thrace in 513. Anastasius left no clear heir, and on his death **Justin** (r. 518–27), head of the palace guard, seized the throne. Justin was of humble origins and relied heavily on his nephew **Justinian**. He restored **Chalcedonian Christianity** and developed good relations with the **Ostrogoths** of Italy and the **Vandals** of North Africa. Abroad, his reign was generally peaceful, apart from a minor campaign against Persia in early 527.

In Gaul, **Clovis**, king of the **Franks**, had defeated Syagrius, ruler of a Roman enclave near Soissons, in 486, followed by the Alamanni and the Thuringians in 491. The **Visigothic kingdom** in southwestern Gaul was his next target, and it collapsed after a major Frankish victory at Vouillé in 507. Clovis's marriage to Clotilde, daughter of the Burgundian king Chilperic, led him to convert to **Catholic Christianity** in the 490s, and he maintained cordial relations with the Byzantine emperor Anastasius, who gave him the title of consul c. 508. Near the end of his reign, Clovis added several previously independent Frankish domains to his kingdom, notably that of the Ripuarian Franks. On his death in 511, Clovis's kingdom was divided among his four sons—Theuderic, Childebert, Chlodomer, and Chlothar. This tradition of subdivision would weaken the **Merovingian dynasty**, as the descendants of Clovis were known. The Merovingians ruled Francia (France) until the 8th century.



This 6th-century mosaic, from the church of San Vitale, Ravenna, Italy, depicts Emperor Justinian with his retinue of officials, guards, and clergy.

THE REIGN OF THE BYZANTINE EMPEROR JUSTINIAN (r. 527–65) began with important reforms. In 528, he commissioned a new law code to replace the confusion he had inherited. The new code, the **Codex Justinianus**, came into force in 529 (revised in 534). An enthusiastic builder, Justinian ordered the building of the great



THEODORA (c.500–548)

Theodora, who Justinian married in 525, had once been a prostitute and the mistress of Hecebolus, the governor of Libya Pentapolis. After the death of his adoptive mother, Empress Lucipina (who had opposed their relationship), Justinian had the law changed in 524 to allow him to marry Theodora. Theodora became a forceful empress, stiffening Justinian's resolve during the Nika revolt and acting as the protector of Monophysite Christians—she was one herself—during times of persecution.

church of **Hagia Sophia** in 534. The greatest challenge to his rule came in 532, when rioting among the Blue and Green chariot-racing factions got out of hand and turned into the **Nika Revolt**. The uprising almost caused Justinian to flee Constantinople, and its suppression killed 30,000 rebels.

With his throne secure, Justinian looked abroad. In 533 he sent an army under **Belisarius** to Vandal-controlled North Africa, where **Gelimer** had deposed King Hilderic, a Byzantine ally. On September 13, Belisarius defeated Gelimer's army at **Ad Decimum**, just outside Carthage, and Vandal resistance collapsed. Carthage was occupied and Gelimer was sent as a captive to Constantinople.

The rapid conquest of the **Vandal kingdom** encouraged Justinian to intervene in Italy. An excuse was provided by the murder in April 535 of his friend **Amalasuintha**, the Ostrogothic queen. Belisarius launched a strike against Italy in 535, landing on Sicily with 7,000 troops. Sicily was secured by the end of 535, and Belisarius moved into southern Italy early in 536. He took Naples after a three-week siege, causing the Ostrogothic king, **Vitigis**, to retreat northward. On December 9, 536, in a symbolic restoration of the empire's lost provinces, the **Byzantine army occupied Rome**. Rome was soon besieged by Goths. Belisarius finally took the Ostrogothic capital of **Ravenna** in 540. Suspicions that he planned to become emperor led to his recall, encouraging more Ostrogothic resistance.

